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LARGE The Carnival of Broken Dreams

large A Folk Horror Social Commentary adventure for Fate's Edge

large Tiers: IIII • Length: 36 sessions • Themes: Temptation, public goods, predatory spectacle

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What this is

A traveling nightmarket of tents, music, and miracles glides the traderoads between Silkstrand and Thepyrgos. It grants wishespreciselyand charges a price in things people didn't know they valued. As the Desire Index rises, a town's intangibles unravel: lullabies vanish, bellrights lapse, markets drift off schedule. The party can expose terms, retune the engine, or divert its appetite before the carnival moves on.

This module leans on core Fate's Edge procedures:

tem Position DV: earn leverage first (permits, bells, seats), then roll. tem Timers: visible pressure on community, appetite, and exposure. tem SB spends (on 1s): crowds shift, contracts "correct," law turns midscene. tem Diamonds: codified outcomes (e.g., Witness Seal, Stage Permit) that move Position without a roll.

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Where it fits (Setting)

tem Silkstrand bridgewards crave spectacle and shortcuts to prestige; Diamonds like Bellmark, Stage Permit, and Witness Seal reflect local bureaucracy and showrights. tem Thepyrgos lawbybell and stairrights make crowd scenes volatile; a single peal can flip Position or freeze a performance. tem Patron Orbit (Lore): The carnival often courts Livaea (Desire) devotees and accepts etiquette enforcement by Mab's envoysneither must be the villain. Treat them as cultural gravity and flavor, not rules engines.

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Adventure Summary (at a glance)

Act I Firelight

Parade arrives; a "free wish" hooks an important NPC. The party sees a miracle, then the missing price.

Act II Mirrors Ledgers

Investigate tents, negotiate terms, steal leverage from the Ledger Wagon, and win Diamonds to constrain predation.

Act III The Calliope Heart

A public performance powers the engine. Break one pillar Rhythm, Mask Index, or Ticket Chain to starve it or retool it.

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Core Timers (start values)

tem **Desire Index** [6] local wishrate and price magnitude. tem **Community Unraveling** [6] customs, names, and bonds fray. tem **Carnival Appetite** [8] grand act when filled. tem **Spotlight Heat** [4] how targeted the party is by staff.

Tick examples

tem Desire Index: each granted wish (+1), heavy crowd teaser (+1 if unopposed). tem Unraveling: any wish taken without informed terms (+1), public goods priced (+1). tem Appetite: each botched sabotage the engine can “eat” (+1), retuning misfire (+1). tem Heat: public confrontations, breaking taboos, or humiliating staff (+1).

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The Desire Tax (custom procedure)

Idea: Every fulfilled wish costs something the wisher didn’t know they valued. As more wishes accrue, the Desire Index rises and prices escalate.

Per Wish (run this)

tem State the desire. Tag: Need, Ambition, or Indulgence. tem Set the base price. Choose/roll on Taxable Intangibles (below). tem Apply rate. Tax Magnitude = 1 + Desire Index. Scale the loss accordingly. tem Resolve. The carnival fulfills; the price disappears from the wisher or town. tem Advance timers. Desire Index +1; Unraveling +1 if terms weren’t fully understood; Appetite +1 on greedy staff actions.

Taxable Intangibles (d10)

tem Private memory tem Unconscious skill tem Social grace tem Local luck/wind tem Shared custom tem Legal right (bellmark/stairpass) tem Relationship texture tem Placename tem Future possibility tem Invisible boundary (e.g., where a river “should” bend)

Fallout thresholds

tem 01: Rumors, coincidences, sampler wishes. tem 23: Faces feel unfamiliar; crowds drift to the midway. tem 45: Names slip; permits misread; bells mistime. tem 6+: Foundational loss unless stopped.

Countermeasures

tem Informed consent: If the exact price is spoken and voluntarily accepted ß reduce Magnitude by 1 (min 1) and don’t tick Unraveling. tem Substitution: PCs may volunteer an equalvalue price to block Appetite. tem Audited wish: Present a Witness Seal (Diamond) to force staff to state the exact terms; 1 DV vs carnival staff.

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Diamonds (codified leverage)

[1][1] line **Diamond** What it does Typical Position shift

line Witness Seal Compels staff to name the exact price aloud. Controlled β Dominant (social)

Stage Permit One lawful interruption of a live act. Controlled β Dominant (onstage)

Bellmark of Honest Trade Shields from predatory refinances. 1 DV for term disputes

Mirror Warrant Break a mirror without accruing Heat. Ignore one glamour penalty

Calliope Key Retune the engine's rhythm for a beat. Group +1 Position vs engine hazards

line

Hand out Diamonds as scene goals or rewards for clever prep. They change Position first; then roll.

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Sites set pieces

Firelight Parade (opening)

Mood: Lanterns, brass, thrilled hush.

Default Position: Controlled (DV 3). Public accusations raise DV to 4.

Beats: Free raffleish “won” by a sympathetic NPC; staff “clarifies” nothing.

SB spends (on 1s): Confetti seals a microcontract; crowd tilts; a bell cue flips the scene order.

Midway of Masks

Trybeforebuy illusions “prove” the wish.

tem Risk: Each test without refusal ticks Desire Index +1. tem Failforward: Small boon gained but a habit is lost (whistling, prayer, smile cadence) until resolved.

House of Honest Mirrors

Shows visitors as they believe themselves to be; mirrors hold their price ledger.

tem Position: Controlled (DV 4). tem Action: Break a mirror under Mirror Warrant to read its ledger safely. tem Heat on miss: Mirror shards animate and reassign masks midscene.

The Wishwright's Tent

Velvetlaw negotiation.

tem Leverage: Witness Seal or Bellmark shifts Position; otherwise staff “assumes the difference.” tem Magic: Divination finds missing clauses but attracts Livaeatouched attendants.

Ledger Wagon (backstage heist)

A traveling records office; prices are written as negative space on vellum.

tem Position: Controlled β Desperate if loud (DV 45). tem Reward: Copying a ledger grants leverage to unwind a price; the reader temporarily loses a related social grace.

The Calliope Heart (finale)

Engine under the stage with three pillars:

tem Rhythm: crowd cadence; break with countersong (Cantor), bell offbeat, or Calliope Key.

tem Mask Index: who plays which role; scramble labels or sanctify a mask. tem Ticket Chain: consent tokens; reroute or void them with contract sigils.

Break any one pillar to starve the engine or change its appetite.

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NPC Roster

Maestra Pann (Ringmaster) velvet coaxing, bell cues, spectacle first.

tem Wants: Growth, clean shows, no scandal. tem Moves: Change the beat; elevate stakes; flatter a rival into compliance. tem Tell: Twofinger bell count before a hard turn.

Mr. Vellum (LedgerClerk) papery whisper, ink under nails.

tem Wants: Balanced books (ethos of fairness... on their terms). tem Moves: “Correct” a contract; split a cost between bystanders; misfile your name. tem Tell: Checks quill nib before lying.

The Cotton Witch (Livaeatouched) sugared lips, cravingsasmagic.

tem Wants: To feed your appetite until you consent to anything. tem Moves: Offer a sweeter “trial”; mirror your desire; name your envy aloud. tem Tell: Hums when you hesitate.

Harlequin of Courts (Mab’s Envoy) etiquette duels as combat.

tem Wants: Order, pretty rules, public victories. tem Moves: Demand apology; set a forfeit; bind you to a bit of theatre. tem Tell: Bows before cuts.

Ticket Twins (Ushers) synchronized blinks, bright patter.

tem Wants: Throughput, safety theatre. tem Moves: Reassign seating; isolate meddlers; “check” tokens that edit consent after the fact.

Add one local anchor NPC (Bellwarden, Market Matron, or a child prodigy) to personify the stakes.

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Procedures guidance

Position DV (quick ladder)

tem Dominant: Tier+2 permits in hand, crowd yours, law on your side. tem Controlled: Tier+3 proper intros, stable ground. tem Desperate: Tier+4+ taboo broken, wrong place/time, Heat high.

Use Diamonds to change Position before rolling. Reward prep with downshifts.

SB spend menus (sample)

Parade Grounds

tem Free wish “won” by an allied NPC ß Desire Index +1. tem Crowd surge separates PC from their leverage. tem Confetticontract sticks to a sleeve: tear it = social harm.

Backstage

tem Ledger page sticks to a shadow: lose a habit until returned. tem A bell cue retimes the scene: +1 DV until the beat is broken. tem Mask roles swap: allies briefly count as “audience.”

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Act structure (with beats)

Act I Firelight (12 sessions)

tem Hook via rafflewish to a sympathetic townie. tem Identify the Desire Tax through consequences. tem Win first Diamond (Witness Seal) in a fairgame contest or etiquette duel. tem Timers: Desire Index 12; Unraveling 1; Heat 1.

Failforward examples

tem Calling out the price in public: you force a lesser cost to be named, but it latches onto a bystander unless countered. tem Breaking the line: you reach the tent; a child slips toward a booth you shut down.

Act II Mirrors Ledgers (13 sessions)

tem House of Honest Mirrors ß Wishwright's Tent ß Ledger Wagon heist. tem Earn Stage Permit or Mirror Warrant. tem Decide whether to regulate, starve, or divert the engine. tem Timers: Desire Index 34; Unraveling 34; Appetite 35; Heat 23.

Failforward examples

tem Mirror smash: gain a ledger shard; your reflection walks off (lose a habit) until reunited. tem Retune calliope: DV 1 but Appetite +1 (the engine takes a taste).

Act III The Calliope Heart (1 session)

tem Public show as ritual; break Rhythm, Mask Index, or Ticket Chain. tem Choose an ending and settle prices.

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Endings

tem **Expose Regulate:** Carnival stays but all wishes require informed, spoken terms. Unraveling clears; Livaea's devotees take interest in you. tem **Starve the Engine:** Break any pillar; tents collapse; debts become letters and must be handdelivered back. tem **Divert the Appetite:** Offer a greater, voluntary group vow; the carnival leaves on a promise and returns when it matures.

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Magic Talents (tablefacing prompts)

tem Cantors: Lead countercadence; 1 DV vs crowd sway. Risk: echochoir ticks Desire Index. tem Runekeepers: Stamp faircontract sigils; negate one clause (Obligation may rise if Courts are offended). tem Invokers: Call a neutral market spirit to enforce equivalence; it tithes your luck. tem Casters: Euclidean wards block mirror tricks; wards hum appetites that draw the Cotton Witch. tem Summoners: Bind a "lostandfound" spirit to return a price; it pockets a token from you.

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XP milestones (suggested)

tem Name a Price (publicly, precisely): +6 XP tem Save a Wisher (undo a price without harming others): +8 XP tem Backstage Leverage (copy/steal ledger): +6 XP tem Retune the Engine (break a pillar or reduce Desire Index to 0): +10 XP tem Community Heals (clear Unraveling before departure): +12 XP tem Session Base: +6 XP per session for exploration, roleplay, and setbacks

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Random tables

d6 Midway Booths

tem GuesstheSecret (mirror reads you) tem Cotton Alchemy (flavors as feelings) tem Fortune Stair (ministairright lottery) tem Prize Hook (catch your “best self”) tem Lantern Maze (lefts are regrets) tem Mask Painter (face becomes contract text)

d6 Crowd Moments

tem Chant swells offbeat tem Bell rings early tem Child returns with a stranger’s voice tem Vendors swap prices midsentence tem Duel of apologies erupts tem Parade pauses; all eyes on you

d6 Prices That Hurt Just Right

tem The last note of a cradlesong tem Market wind that smells of dye tem The shortcut only you knew tem Your knack for remembering faces tem The right to ring the bell once tem The name of the street you grew up on

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Session 1 quickstart (3 hours)

tem Cold Open (15 min): Parade arrives; rafflewish triggers. tem Investigation Beat (45 min): Midway of Masks or Honest Mirrors. tem Pressure Beat (30 min): Public callout; win Witness Seal. tem Choice Beat (30 min): Who to help first; start or cool a timer. tem Climax (30/40 min): Minidebate or mirror heist. tem Fallout (10 min): Hand out a Diamond; foreshadow the Calliope.

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Safety tone

tem This arc spotlights exploitation and “price of desire.” Use upfront consent tools. Swap any personalprice beats for harmlessbutmeaningful community intangibles (songs, routes, customs) when that serves your table.

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Printables (dropin)

Timers

tem Desire Index [] [] [] [] [] tem Community Unraveling [] [] [] [] [] tem Carnival Appetite
[] [] [] [] [] [] tem Spotlight Heat [] [] [] []

Diamonds (handouts)

tem Witness Seal Stage Permit Bellmark of Honest Trade Mirror Warrant Calliope Key
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Ties followons

tem Silk Velvet Arc: Belllaw and etiquette duels at the carnival foreshadow Crimson Masque.
tem Steps Into Sorrow: If a town loses its lullaby or streetname, those shards can seed
sorrowechoes on the Bridge or in SevenSorrows.

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Running note

Keep rolls scarce by rewarding preparation with Position shifts. Spend 1s to move the crowd,
“correct” papers, or hit a new bell cue that alters scene order. The carnival is a machine for
desirelet the party decide whether to smash, regulate, or reaim it.